

Guided Case Conversations

Conservation Biology: Spring 2026

Assignment Overview

In this recurring assignment, students will work in small groups to **lead a structured, whole-class discussion** focused on a **real conservation action or management decision**.

Rather than giving a formal presentation, your role is to **guide discussion** around:

- How conservation threats are defined and prioritized
- How progress or success is measured
- Whether goals are well-defined using **SMART goals**
- What ethical, social, or equity-related tradeoffs are involved

Each facilitation should fill around **20–30 minutes** of class time. The instructor may add examples or extend discussion afterward as time allows.

This format mirrors how conservation professionals evaluate projects in meetings, review panels, and collaborative decision-making settings.

What Counts as a “Case”?

Your group will select **one real, publicly documented conservation project or action** involving a clear decision or intervention.

Acceptable examples include:

- Species recovery or management programs
- Habitat protection, restoration, or connectivity initiatives
- Reintroduction, translocation, or captive breeding programs
- Zoo, NGO, or government conservation initiatives
- Conservation education or community-based projects

Your case must:

- Be real (not hypothetical)
- Be publicly documented
- Include explicit goals, actions, or outcomes

Primary research papers are **optional**, not required.

Group Preparation (Submitted Before Class)

Each group submits a **Preparation sheet** before their facilitation day. This is graded for **completion**.

In-Class Facilitation (20–30 minutes)

Context framing (5 min)

- Introduce the case and decision

- Reading directly from notes is allowed

Presentation slides are not required, but you are welcome to share visuals using canva, powerpoint, google slides, or extra handouts if it helps you introduce key information.

Guided whole-class discussion (15–20 min)

- Ask your prepared questions
- Encourage multiple perspectives
- Your role is to guide, not lecture

Brief synthesis (2–5 min)

- Summarize key insights
- Reflect on whether goals and metrics captured conservation success

Each group member should have a visible role.

Assessment

Criterion	Points
Preparation sheet submitted on time	4
Clear explanation of the conservation decision & threats	4
Thoughtful analysis of metrics & quantification	4
Accurate use of SMART goals	4
Engagement with ethical or social tradeoffs	4
Effective facilitation & shared participation	4
Total	24

This is **not** a public-speaking performance. Structure and preparation matter more than polish.

Peer Engagement (5 points, completion credit)

On days you are **not** facilitating, you will complete a short peer engagement form at the end of class.